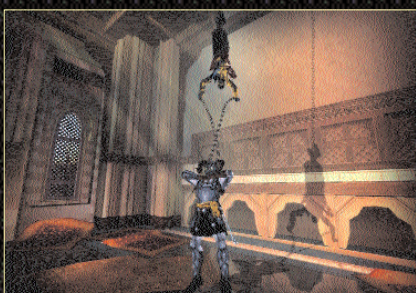
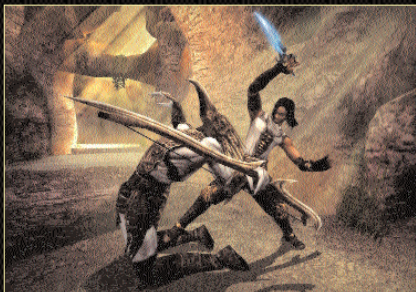


to open a door, to more complex ones that require you to run around manipulating multiple levers or switches. They often require a bit of thinking—but they're never overly frustrating; I found them a welcome experience.

Welcome To The Real Dark Side

Every so often, the Prince transforms into the Dark Prince who, instead of having to use a secondary weapon to attack enemies, can use the Daggertail. This results in some beautiful, swirling attack animation. The Dark Prince is a very strong melee fighter, and is nearly invincible in combat since his health is completely replenished every time you collect Sand. (Which enemies drop at death.) However, like the Sandwraith in *WW*, his health constantly decreases, which often makes for some tense acrobatic sequences.

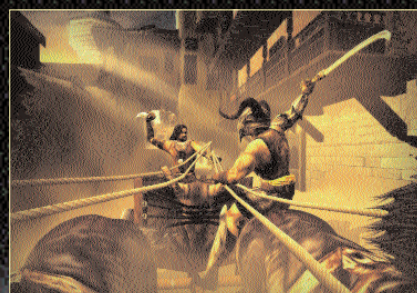


Rating: 9/10
Platform: PS2
Developer: Ubisoft (Montreal)
Publisher: Ubisoft
Distributor: E-Xpress Interactive Software Pvt Ltd
Contact: 022-28850245
Price: Rs. 2,999

The Dark Prince comes with his own stealth kills; he likes to strangle enemies with his chain, and can also use the Daggertail to grab and swing from objects such as lamp fixtures. The playing style of the Dark Prince, therefore, brings variety to the gameplay.

Pretty Prince, Poor Polygons

Graphics-wise, the game is definitely a notch better than *WW*, but the improvement isn't dramatic. The Prince's model looks more detailed (and more princely too; he no longer looks like the scruffy ragamuffin he was in *WW*), but when you see the



in-game cutscenes, it's easy to notice that many models suffer from a low polygon count. You don't notice it outside the cutscenes, however, and the fighting animations, as before, are quite smooth and realistic. But where *TTT* really excels (as did the previous two games) are the environmental graphics. The dusty streets and burning rooftops of Babylon, the dark sewers underneath the city, the palace of the king, the temple, and the moonlit hanging gardens of Babylon—none of these will fail to disappoint. The lighting effects are particularly impressive, and everything seems immersed in a beautiful glow. It's a real pleasure to see the effect of light streaming down into rooms from windows or cracks in the ceiling.

The rock music from the previous game is gone. Perhaps it's just as well, since it might have seemed grossly out of place in *TTT*. Instead, you have music that's sounds a bit more traditional and in tune with the setting of the game. Naturally, action sequences will involve faster, louder music, while players wandering through empty areas will experience slower, almost sad vocal music. On the whole, the music is up to the mark, as is the voice acting of all the characters.

Throughout the game, players will be kept entertained by the conversations and arguments between the Prince and the Dark Prince, or Kaileena's insightful, softly spoken narratives (yes, even though she's dead), which really help keep the story alive.

Prince of Persia: The Two Thrones successfully reduces frustration and monotony, and introduces a number of interesting gameplay elements, ensuring that the game truly lives up to the high standards of, and provides a highly fitting end to, the entire *Prince of Persia* series. If you liked the previous games, you'll surely like this one. If, however, for whatever reason, you didn't like *Warrior Within*, you probably won't like this game either. ■

Madhav Tankha